Sold

By Patricia McCormick

***CAUTION** - This is a **Novel in Verse**. Check tournament event requirements before entering this selection in PROSE.*

***LAKSHMI: (Pg 8)** My stepfather's arm is a withered and useless thing. Broken as a child when there was no money for a doctor, his poor mangled limb pains him during the rainy months and gives him great shame. No one, he says, will hire a one-armed man. **Ama* says we are lucky we have a man at all. She says I am to honor and praise him, respect and thank him for taking us in after my father died.

INTRODUCTION

Statistically Nepal is one of the poorest countries in the world. Desperate to survive, families feel forced to extreme measures to survive. Each year, nearly 12,000 Nepali girls are sold by their families into a life of sexual slavery in the brothels of India.

Meet Lakshmi. She is 13 years old and this is her story. Sold by Patricia McCormick

LAKSHMI: (Pg 48-49) I put the baby in a basket on my back and go about my chores. [Ama's] steps are slow and

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heavy, and she stops often in her work to shake her head and sigh. At noon, I warm the remains of yesterday's soup, feed it to the baby, then tighten my waistcloth so my own hungry stomach will think it is full. Then I go in search of Ama and find her weeping. *(to mother)* "What is it, Ama?" Ama wipes her cheek with the hem of her shawl.

AMA: Your stepfather has said you must go to the city and earn your keep as a maid.

LAKSHMI: *(to mother)* "This is good news, Ama," . . . *(to audience)* my voice full of a boldness I did not know I had. *(to mother)* "There will be one less mouth to feed here, and I will send my wages home." **(Pg 52-55)** *(to audience)* The next morning my stepfather brings me to Bajai Sita's store.

FATHER: *(to Bajai)* Lakshmi wants to go to work in the city.

BAJAI: *(to Lakshmi)* Are you willing to do whatever is asked of you?

LAKSHMI: I nod. She goes behind a curtain and returns with the stranger in the yellow dress. The woman looks me over head to toe, then addresses my stepfather.

AUNTIE: How much do you want for her?

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LAKSHMI: My stepfather squints. He takes in the costly fabric of the woman's dress, the baubles on her ears, the silver bangles on her wrist. "One thousand rupees," he says. There are not that many rupees in the world!

AUNTIE: *(circling and inspecting Lakshmi)* She has no hips. And she's plain as porridge. I'll give you five hundred.

LAKSHMI: I do not understand. I can carry a load of firewood so heavy it would put a man to shame, and my legs are sturdy enough to climb the mountain a dozen times in one day. What does it matter that I have no hips yet? My stepfather says he knows the going rate for a young girl like me.

FATHER: *(to Bajai)* No less than eight hundred.

LAKSHMI: My stepfather counts the money, then counts it again.

BAJAI: *(to Lakshmi)* Your family will get nothing, not one rupee, if you do not obey your new auntie. Do you understand?

LAKSHMI: *(to audience)* I don't. I don't understand at all. A great deal of money has just been paid for work I have not yet done. But I nod. **(Pg 72-73)** Auntie takes me into one of the rooms.

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AUNTIE: *(disdainfully)* Take off those filthy hill clothes.

LAKSHMI: She holds out a pink dress of cloud fabric and a pair of shoes. I cannot imagine how I will walk freely in such a long, flowing gown, or how I will be able to haul the firewood and scrub the floors in such a fine and flimsy dress.

TRANSITION

And so Auntie takes Lakshmi to a larger village where once again she is Sold.

LAKSHMI: **(Pg 74-75)** Auntie is speaking to a man in a tongue I do not understand. It seems as though they are talking about me now. The man points to me and asks Auntie a question. The answer, as best I can tell, is the number 12. "How old are you?" he says in my language. I tell him I am thirteen. He wheels around and slaps Auntie across the face, and she turns from a woman of queenly bearing to a frightened child. I fall to my knees and beg the man to forgive me.

Auntie names a price as high as a mountain. The man spits. Auntie goes high. The man goes low. I do not know what they have agreed to. But I do know this: he gives her

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nearly enough money to buy a water buffalo.

TRANSITION

Alone with yet another stranger, Lakshimi still believes she is being taken to her new job as a maid in the large Indian city of Kolkata.

LAKSHMI: **(Pg 90-91)** Finally, we tum down an alley and arrive in front of a metal gate held fast with a heavy chain. Uncle takes a key from his vest, opens the lock, and hurries me inside. This place is dark as a cave, and it smells of liquor and incense. As my eyes adjust, I see a dozen sleeping girls, some in the comers, some on rope cots. *(to Uncle)* "What kind of place is this?"

UNCLE: Happiness House. Auntie Mumtaz will explain it all to you.

LAKSHMI: In the weak morning light, I see that the girls are wearing dresses of every color. They have heavy silver bangles on their wrists and ankles, and earrings of gold and jewels. Their eyes are painted with black crayon, and their lips are drawn on like red chilis. **(Pg 92-94)** Inside a darkened chamber, a fat woman in a purple sari lounges on a cot. She has folds of flesh like roti dough at her waist, and a face as plump as an overripe mango.

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She surveys me head to toe, then spits.

MUMTAZ: How much?

UNCLE: Fifteen thousand.

LAKSHMI: Uncle goes high, the woman goes low. Eventually Uncle shrugs and gives up. The woman takes a record book out from inside the folds of her dress. She writes down the number 10,000. *(long beat)* I don't know why I am in this strange house. It seems as though this Auntie Mumtaz is my new mistress. She is a strict one, to be sure, but I will prove myself to her. And then my mother will have a new dress, shoes for the cold season, even a new shawl made of the finest yarn. My little brother will have fruit and curds twice a day and a jacket of yak fur. **(Pg 102-104)** Mumtaz studies me.

MUMTAZ: Are you ready to go to work?

LAKSHMI: I nod and say yes, then nod again, although I do not understand how these city people do their chores in such fine clothes. I follow Mumtaz down a hallway lined with tiny rooms. We pass by girls sitting cross-legged on the floor. Girls drawing on tiger eyes. Girls spraying themselves with flower water. We go up some stairs, down another hallway, then into a room where an old

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man is lying on a bed. His skin is yellow and he has tufts of hair poking out from his ears. Mumtaz speaks kindly to him and I wonder if he is sick. Mumtaz points to me and says something to the old man. He licks his palm and smoothes down his hair. Something is not right here. I don't know what is going on, but it is not right, not right at all. Mumtaz pats the edge of the bed.

MUMTAZ: Don't be afraid. Come here, now.

LAKSHMI: I don't move. Her voice turns hard.

MUMTAZ: Get over here, you ignorant girl.

LAKSHMI: Then Mumtaz flies at me. She grabs me by the hair and drags me across the room. She flings me onto the bed next to the old man. And then he is on top of me, holding me down with the strength of ten men. He kisses me with lips that are slack and wet and taste of onions. His teeth dig into my lower lip. Underneath the weight of him, I cannot see or move or breathe. He fumbles with his pants, forces my legs apart, and I can feel him . . . I gasp for air and kick and squirm. He thrusts his tongue in my mouth. And I bite down with all my might.

OLD MAN: Aghh!

LAKSHMI: . . . and I am running. Running down the hall,

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past the other girls, losing my fancy city shoes along the way.

TRANSITION

But this is only the beginning; starved, beaten and drugged, Lakshmi is eventually broken and moved from a locked room into the general population of girls. She learns from them everything she needs to know to survive.

LAKSHMI: **(Pg 141-143)** While Anita and Pushpa stand in front of the mirror, painting their faces, Shahanna explains everything to me.

SHAHANNA: Before, when you were in the locked room, Mumtaz sent the customers to you. Now, you must do what it takes to make them choose you. Tell the customers that you are 12 or Mumtaz will beat you senseless. Do whatever the customer asks of you. Otherwise, he will beat you senseless. Then he will do whatever he likes and leave without paying.

PUSHPA: Always wash yourself with a wet rag after the man is finished. This will keep you from getting a disease. Once a month a government woman comes to the back door with a basket of condoms. Take a handful and hide them under your mattress. If an old man is at the door,

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bat your eyelashes and act the part of a little girl. He will pay extra for this. Press your shawl to your nose with the back of your hand when you must bring a dirty man to your bed. He will leave nothing but his smell, the stink of sweat, and hair oil and liquor and man. But you can use your shawl to block the worst of it.

LAKSHMI: Anita turns away from the mirror, transformed from a crooked-faced country girl into a tiger-eyed city woman.

ANITA: There is another way to use a shawl.

LAKSHMI: I cannot tell from her always-frowning face if she is being kind or cruel.

ANITA: [The] new girl, the one in your old room . . . Yesterday morning Mumtaz found her hanging from the rafters. *(long beat)*

LAKSHMI: **(Pg 192)** A few days later I pass by a mirror. The face that looks back is that of a corpse. Her eyes are empty. She is old and tired. Old and angry. Old and sad. Old, old, a hundred years old. I speak to her. *"My name is Lakshmi,"* I tell her. *"I am from Nepal. I am 13 years old."*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

SUGGESTIONS: *Practice your Nepali accent*
Sample Video can be found here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7OJTTcfiqzk

Allow your character enough time to process what is going on – respond emotionally and non-verbally as the tale unfolds.

**"Ama" is the Napali term for Mother. Lakshmi is pronounced "luck-shmee"*

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